

German Breweries in Texas

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Overview

- Every community possessing a sizable German population (except Nacogdoches and El Paso) in Texas established a brewery.
- Innovations such as pasteurization, railroads, and refrigeration led to rapid growth, allowing breweries access to an entirely new market of customers.
- Beginning as personal home projects, breweries slowly grew into commercial businesses that sold beer locally, and eventually became large, mechanized establishments which competed nationwide.

Home Brewing

- After immigrating to Texas in 1842, home breweries became common among Germans.
- Due to the breweries' small scale, the 1850 census listed only 19 brewers and distillers.
- Home brewers weren't looking to turn a profit, just have available beer in newly settled towns.
- Technological limitations (no railroad, refrigeration, pasteurization, etc.) prevented transport of beer to areas far away without spoiling its quality.

Rise of Commercial Breweries

- As Germans settled down, the size of their breweries began to grow.
- William Menger's Western Brewery (1855-1878):
 - Formed in San Antonio in 1855.
 - Considered the first commercial brewery.
 - Largest brewery in Texas when it shutdown in 1878.
- Heinrich Kreische's Kreische Brewery:
 - Opened in La Grange in 1872.
 - Considered second commercial brewery in Texas.
 - By 1879, became the third largest brewery in the state.
- Many brewers were also in the hospitality business, running hotels on the side.
 - Ex: William Menger (San Antonio), Thomas Ingenhuitt (Comfort), Charles Nimitz (Fredericksburg)



Rise of Mechanized, Large-Scale Breweries

- With easier transportation of goods via railroads, Texas breweries exponentially grew in order to compete on the national stage.
- Lone Star Brewery (1884-1918):
 - Built in San Antonio in 1884
 - Formed by Adolphus Busch and a group of local San Antonio businessmen.
 - First large-scale, mechanized brewery in Texas.
 - Sold beer in California, Mexico, and Texas.



Lone Star Brewery

German Breweries: Prohibition Era

- Beginning on January 16, 1919, 13 commercial breweries across Texas were shutdown.
- Brewers were forced to dabble in other professions temporarily.
- Otto Koehler's Pearl Brewery made ice cream and ran a sign company.
- Kosmos Spoetzl (owner of Shiner) sold ice.
- For the most part, only larger Texas breweries were able to survive the prohibition era and reopen afterwards.



Pearl Brewery (San Antonio)

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